

Origins, Social Identity, and Documentary History of the De/Dey Family of East Bengal, c. 1200–1947

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Abstract

The Bengali Hindu surname De/Dey (দে / দেয়) derives from Sanskrit *deva* and crystallised as a hereditary Kayastha identifier between 1231 and 1317 CE in association with the Vaishnava Deva dynasty of Bikrampur and Sonargaon. Within the Bangaja (eastern Bengal) Kayastha hierarchy, Dey families occupy the *Mahapatra* sub-tier — the highest Maulika rank — attested independently in Vidyānidhi's *Sambandha Nirṇaya* (1896). Genetic evidence from Pagani *et al.* (2017) indicates Y-haplogroup H1a* for a Dey individual, consistent with indigenous Bengal rather than steppe-migrant origin. A micro-historical case study centres on *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey* (AIR 1938 Cal 216), involving the author's grandfather, an umbrella manufacturer in Mymensingh Burra Bazar.

Keywords: De/Dey surname, Bengali Kayastha, Deva dynasty, Bangaja system, Kashyapa gotra, Mahapatra, Mymensingh, kulagrantha, population genetics

1. Introduction

The Bengali Hindu surname system is among the most historically layered caste-identification mechanisms in the subcontinent. Unlike the relatively simple pan-Indian Varna classification, the Bengali system evolved through a series of politically motivated genealogical reforms — beginning with the Sena dynasty’s formalisation of *kulinism* in the twelfth century and continuing through the Deva dynasty’s patronage of the *kulagrantha* tradition in the thirteenth — to produce an internally ranked hierarchy of extraordinary complexity. The Bengali Kayastha caste, one of Bengal’s three traditional upper castes alongside Brahmin and Baidya, contains within itself no fewer than ninety-nine ranked surnames in the genealogical texts, with precise gradations of clan rank governing marriage eligibility, ritual status, and social precedence for eight centuries.

Within this system, the surname De/Dey occupies a position that is simultaneously distinguished and contested. It is *maulika* — original local Bengal stock, predating the legendary Kannauj migration of the five Kulin clans — yet *siddha*, elevated by royal decree above the ordinary body of the caste. It is geographically distinctive, more prevalent in eastern Bengal (present-day Bangladesh) than in the western Radhi-tradition districts, and associated with a specific medieval genealogical framework — the Bangaja system — that organised Kayastha society in eastern Bengal from the thirteenth century onward. Its name derives from one of Sanskrit’s most generative roots, *deva* (divine), and traces most plausibly to the Hindu Vaishnava Deva kings of Bikrampur and Sonargaon, whose fall to the Bengal Sultanate in 1317 CE dispersed the Hindu elite across the Bengal delta.

The same De/Dey cognomen appears — with different genealogical histories — among Suvarna Banik, Teli, and Kansari communities.¹ This paper concentrates on the Kayastha tradition, which represents the historically primary and socially dominant use of the surname. The investigation is necessarily interdisciplinary. Copper-plate land grants from Damodaradeva (1234, 1236, 1243 CE) provide the medieval anchor. Five volumes of Nagendranath Basu’s *Banger Jatiya Itihas* supply the most extensive indigenous compilation of the Dey family’s genealogical tradition. Three additional Kayastha social texts — Lalmohan Vidyanidhi’s *Sambandha Nirnaya* (1896), Nagendranath Basu’s *Kayastha Barna Nirnay* (1913), and Girishchandra Basu’s *Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi* (1928) — provide independent corroboration at critical points. Colonial ethnographic and census records supply the institutional record from the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. And Pagani *et al.* (2017) provides the only published direct genetic evidence for a Bengali Dey individual.

2. Source Methodology: Kulagranthas and the Critical Use of Genealogical Evidence

The *kulagrantha* — literally “family text” — is a Bengali genre of genealogical literature produced primarily between the fourteenth and early nineteenth centuries by professional genealogists (*ghatakas*) who maintained descent records for high-caste families. Kulagranthas served as social charters: they were recited at weddings and *shraddha* ceremonies, and functioned to validate or contest the rank of prospective marriage partners. As Kumkum Chatterjee observes, they “validate relationships between groups” and should be read as “ideologically purposive social documents” rather than as historical chronicles.² Ronald Inden’s palaeographic finding is critical: “all [kulagrantha manuscripts are], on palaeographic grounds, assigned to the late eighteenth or early nineteenth centuries,”³ meaning internal dating claims cannot be accepted at face value without independent corroboration. Inden also notes that the genealogical sections were “corporate property” of subcastes, with content “approved” by communal consensus — a process structurally sympathetic to legitimating inflation. Kulagranthas tell us a great deal about how communities wished to understand themselves, and considerably less — without independent corroboration — about the objective facts of medieval history.

Nagendranath Basu (1866–1938) compiled the most extensive published collection of kulagrantha material in his multi-volume *Banger Jatiya Itihas* (1911–1933). Basu was, however, also the founder of the Kayastha Sabha (1902) and editor of *Kayastha Patrika* — an explicit Kayastha advocacy organisation operating at a moment when the community’s legal dvija status was contested in the colonial courts. Inden explicitly qualifies his reliance on Basu: “although many of his arguments about the origin of the kāyasthas of Bengal cannot be taken too seriously, I have relied heavily on the hundreds of texts which he collected.”³ Projit Bihari Mukharji characterises Basu’s interpretive framework as that of a “dedicated Kayastha propagandist.”⁴

This paper treats Basu accordingly: as a primary compiler of the kulagrantha tradition whose assembled texts are evidence for that tradition’s claims, and whose own interpretive glosses require independent verification. Claims are evaluated against three categories: **Category A** (corroborated by sources independent of the kulagrantha tradition — epigraphy, colonial records); **Category B** (consistent with the broader corpus and cross-attested in multiple sources, without epigraphic corroboration); **Category C** (resting on a single manuscript chain or Basu’s own inference).

3. Etymology and Nomenclature: From *Deva* to *De*

The surname De/Dey derives from the Sanskrit *deva* (देव), “god,” “divine being,” or “celestial.” As a nominal suffix, *-deva* was appended to royal names throughout the Gupta period — Chandraguptadeva, Kumāraguptadeva — signifying divine sanction for royal authority. Administrative surnames such as Datta, Dasa, Naga, and Ghosha appear alongside Brahmin names in Gupta-era documents, pointing to the early crystallisation of an administrative class whose surnames carried Sanskrit ritual weight.⁵

The evolution of the modern surname follows a predictable Bengali phonological pathway: **Deva** → Dev → Deb → De / Dey. The first reduction, from *Deva* to *Dev*, occurs through regular final-vowel deletion common in spoken Sanskrit and early Prakrit. The second shift, from *Dev* to *Deb*, reflects Bengali’s tendency to lenite terminal consonants in colloquial speech. From *Deb*, two modern forms emerge: **De** (formal, literary, dominant in educated East Bengali written registers) and **Dey** (colloquial, dominant in eastern Bengal and diaspora contexts). The variant **Deb** persists in North Bengal, Tripura, and Assam. The De/Dey division is a diaspora phonological regularisation — court records illustrate this directly: *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey* (AIR 1938 Cal 216) titles the respondent “Dey” even though he signed his trademark “De.”

A secondary Sanskrit root, *deya* (देय) — “that which ought to be given,” “a gift” — has been proposed as an alternative derivation, reflecting a family that received a royal or Brahminical land grant. However, the *deva* derivation is more widely attested in the genealogical literature and more consistent with the dynastic history reviewed below.

4. The Deva Dynasty: Historical Evidence and Genealogical Tradition

4.1 Historical Background and the Copper-Plate Evidence (Category A)

The *documented* history of the Deva dynasty begins in the thirteenth century. The Muslim conquest of Bengal under Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khilji (1204 CE) rapidly dismantled the Sena dynasty’s authority.⁶ Into the resulting vacuum in eastern Bengal rose the family of Purushottamadeva, a *gramani* (village headman) of the Comilla-Noakhali region. His son Madhusudanadeva was the first to assume the title *nripati* (king); it is the fourth ruler, Damodaradeva (r. c. 1231–1243 CE), who left the most extensive documentary record.

Three copper-plate land grants of Damodaradeva constitute the only Category A epigraphic evidence for the dynasty: the Mehar Copper Plate (1234 CE, Comilla District), establishing territorial control over Samatata; the Shobharampur Copper Plate (1236

CE, Dhaka District), recording westward extension of Deva power; and the Chittagong Copper Plate (1243 CE), extending Deva reach to Chittagong. Damodaradeva's successor Dasharathadeva left the Adabadi copper plate and is recorded in alliance with Delhi Sultan Ghiyasuddin Balban, dated to c. 1282 CE.⁷ The dynasty maintained its last stronghold at Sonargaon until approximately 1317 CE, when Shamsuddin Firuz Shah's forces took the city.

Critically, none of the surviving copperplates record the Deva dynasty's gotra, genealogical founder, or connection to the ancient capital at Karnasuvarna (modern Murshidabad). The royal *prashastis* employ the conventional Somavamsa ("lunar dynasty") formula borrowed from Sena chancery usage — a legitimating formula that Majumdar characterises as standard political rhetoric rather than genealogical fact.⁸ Living communities of the Deva/De/Dey family in western Bengal are still known as "*Kansona ke De*" — confirming a continuous community identity associated with this place-name — even though the ancient dynastic continuity claimed in kulagrantha foundation myths must be treated as Category C tradition.⁹

4.2 The Gotra System and the Bangaja Dey Family (Category B)

The kulagrantha tradition records a ten-gotra internal structure for the Deva dynasty. The primary Sanskrit verse, from the Dakshin Rariya Kulpanjika as preserved in Basu's *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933),¹⁰ reads: "আলম্যানো গৌতমশ্চ ঘৃতকৌশিক এবচ। মোদগলাঃ কাম্পো বাতস্ত শঙ্খিলাশ্চ পরাশরঃ। ভরদ্বাজো বশিষ্ঠশ্চ দশ দেবে প্রকীৰ্ত্তিতঃ।" — "Alamyana, Gautama, Ghritakaushika, Moudgalya, Kashyapa, Vatsa, Shandilya, Parashar, Bharadvaja, Vashishtha — these ten are renowned in the Deva dynasty." Basu confirms in prose: "The Deva dynasty has 10 gotras, meaning within the single Deva dynasty there are again 10 sub-families."¹⁰

A critical distinction emerges from three independent kulagrantha sources. The **Shandilya** gotra is consistently associated in the tradition with the *kulanayak* or royal ruling line — specifically the Chandradwip branch descended from Danujamardana. The **Alambana** (also Alamyana, Alambayan) gotra is confirmed as the primary gotra of ordinary Maulik De/Dey Kayastha families — the non-royal majority — by three independent attestations: (i) Vidyanidhi's *Sambandha Nirnaya* (1896): "মৌলিকদিগের মধ্যে ... দে আলম্যান ... এই কয়েকটা বঙ্গজ ও দক্ষিণ-রাঁড়ীর মধ্যে সমান আছে" — "Among the Maulikas ... De = Alambana [gotra] ... common to both Bangaja and Dakshin-Radhi";¹¹ (ii) Basu's *Kayastha Barna Nirnay* (1913): "আলম্যান দেব এই চারিঘরের আদিপুরুষ ৯৯৪ শকে চিহ্নিত হইলেও..." — "the founding ancestors of Alambana Dev [and three other lineages] are placed at 994 Saka [= 1072 CE]";¹² (iii) Girishchandra Basu's *Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi* (1928): "আমরা ... আলম্বায়নগোত্রীয় ... দেববংশের গৃহে রক্ষিত প্রাচীন কাগজে

দেখিয়াছি” — “We have seen in ancient papers preserved at homes of Alambayan-gotra Deva dynasty families.”¹³ The *Sambandha Nirnaya*, published independently of Basu’s Bangaja volumes, constitutes non-Basu corroboration for this gotra attribution.

Individual branches follow one of the ten gotras. The author of this paper confirmed from direct family knowledge that his branch follows the **Kashyapa** gotra — the fifth gotra in the ten-gotra verse. This is consistent with Basu’s Dakshin-Rariya Kulpanjika surname-gotra table mapping “পদবী দেব → গোত্র কাশ্যপ” — Deb/Dey family → Kashyapa gotra.¹⁰ The Moudgalya branch produced Raja Sir Radhakanta Deb Bahadur KCSI (1784–1867) of the Shovabazar Raj — author of the *Shabdakalpadruma*, the eight-volume Sanskrit encyclopaedic dictionary.

4.3 The Devavansha Manuscript: An Independent Transmission (Category B)

An independent transmission of the Deva dynasty’s genealogical tradition — distinct from the Batu Bhatta *Deva Bangsha* transmitted through the Deb Roy family of Mymensingh — was reported by Girishchandra Basu (*Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi*, 1928).¹³ An ancient manuscript titled “দেববংশম্” (*Devavansha*) was found c. 1908 CE at the home of advocate Bhairavachandra Ray of Kishoreganj:

“প্রায় ২০ বৎসর পূর্বে ‘দেববংশম্’ নামে যে প্রাচীন হস্তলিপি কিশোরগঞ্জের উকিল ভৈরবচন্দ্র রায় মহাশয়ের গৃহে পাওয়া গিয়াছে তাহাতে কর্ণস্বর্ণের দেবকুল শাণ্ডল্যগোত্রজ এবং ‘ক্ষত্রপকায়স্থ’ দ্বিজাঃ ক্ষত্রয়কুলসম্ভূতাঃ’ বলিয়া উক্ত হইয়াছেন।”

“About twenty years ago [c. 1908 CE], an ancient manuscript named *Devavansha* was found at the home of advocate Bhairavachandra Ray of Kishoreganj. In it, the Deva clan of Karnasuvarna is described as Shandilya gotra, and as ‘Kshatrapa Kayasthas, twice-born, born from Kshatriya families.’”

A second corroboration was reported by High Court advocate Prakashchandra Sarkar, who saw “this same description of the Deva dynasty” in an old notebook preserved at a Gaya Panda’s house.¹³ These two independent sightings — one at Kishoreganj, one at a Gaya Panda’s register — confirm that the Deva dynasty’s genealogical tradition circulated in multiple independent copies. The Kishoreganj location is geographically significant: it is within the Mymensingh administrative division — the same district as Aswini Kumar De (Section 8).

4.4 Danujamardana and the Bangaja System

The figure of Danujamardana is the most historiographically contested element of the Deva dynasty narrative. The dominant numismatic tradition (Bhattasali, Majumdar,

Banglapedia) identifies silver tankas of c. 1416–1418 CE bearing the legend *śrī śrī danujamarddana deva* as coins of Raja Ganesha of Bhaturia — a North Bengal Hindu zamindar who briefly usurped the Ilyas Shahi sultanate — not a Chandradwip Kayastha.¹⁴ Eaton’s revisionist view distinguishes two figures, proposing that a Chandradwipa-based ruler bearing the Danujamarddana title was a descendant of the Sonargaon Deva dynasty, but does not endorse the specifically Kayastha-Shandilya genealogical claim.¹⁵ The kulagrantha tradition (Basu) presents a third position: Danujamardana Dev of Chandradwip (c. 1417 CE) was of Shandilya gotra and the organiser of the Bangaja Kayastha community system.

This paper follows the kulagrantha tradition for the social-historical argument while acknowledging the contested numismatic context. Girishchandra Basu’s *Kayastha Tattwa-Koumudi* (1928) states the community-organising role directly: “দনুজমর্দনই বঙ্গজসমাজের প্রতিষ্ঠাতা” — “Danujamardana was the founder of Bangaja society.”¹³ This independent compilation provides a second kulagrantha-tradition attestation, separate from Nagendranath Basu’s volumes. The established chronology within the tradition is: c. 1231–1317 CE — Deva dynasty of Bikrampur/Sonargaon; 1317 CE — Sonargaon falls; 1318 CE — Vikramaditya Dev founds Chandradwip; c. 1417 CE — the Chandradwip lineage organises the Bangaja Kayastha system.

4.5 The Surname Crystallisation Mechanism

The connection between the Deva dynasty and the De/Dey surname does not rest on a claim that all Bengali Deys are genealogical descendants of the Deva kings. The argument is more precise: the administrative families — scribes, revenue officials, record-keepers — who served the Deva dynasty and adopted the *deva* element as a hereditary surname did so in the context of the dynasty’s dominance and subsequent collapse. The disruption of the 1317 fall catalysed the crystallisation of many Bengali Hindu surnames. In the terminology of the kulagranthas, this is why the De/Dey family is classified as *maulika* (indigenous Bengal stock) rather than *kulin* (Kannauj migrants): their identity crystallised in Bengal, in the administrative shadow of the Deva dynasty.

5. Social Classification: The Kayastha Hierarchy and the Place of De/Dey

5.1 Bengal’s Distinctive Social Structure

As Sanyal established and Bandyopadhyay elaborated, Bengal operated in practice on a two-Varna structure: Brahmin and, collectively, non-Brahmin.¹⁶ Kshatriya and Vaishya

categories were functionally absent as self-reproducing, endogamous Bengali social units. Within the non-Brahmin category, three castes achieved recognised upper-caste (*uchcha-jati*) status: Brahmin, Baidya, and Kayastha — the *bhadralok* class that dominated Bengal’s intellectual, administrative, and commercial life from the fourteenth century onward. The Bengali Kayastha community derives from the administrative class (*kayastha*, “one who stands at the body [of the king]”) documented in Gupta-era inscriptions, and crystallised into a hereditary caste with its own internal hierarchy over the Pala and Sena periods.¹⁷

5.2 The Vaishya Question

Before analysing the Kayastha hierarchy, it is necessary to address directly whether the De/Dey family may be Vaishya (merchant class) rather than Kayastha. Nagendranath Basu’s *Baishya Kanda* (1913; 2nd ed. 1920) is the most extensive indigenous-language compilation of material relating to Bengal’s Vaishya communities, covering the full spectrum of Bengali merchant-class *jatis*: Souluk-Saha, Barendra Saha, Gandha Banik, Shankha Banik, Kamsa Banik, and Suvarna Banik.¹⁸ A Bengali-language text-search of the digitised edition (DLI item `in.ernet.dli.2015.340039`, covering the full 3,334-line 2nd edition of 1920) finds no occurrences of the De or Dey cognomen in any genealogical context. Risley’s *Tribes and Castes of Bengal* (1891) does list “De” as found among Suvarna Banik families, among others¹ — consistent with the general pattern of cognomen diffusion across caste lines — but the De/Dey community does not figure in the Vaishya genealogical tradition as a primary lineage surname. The question — *are the Deys Kayastha or Vaishya as their primary caste identity?* — is answered **Kayastha** by all available evidence.

5.3 The Kulin System and the Siddha Maulika Position

The internal hierarchy of Bengali Kayasthas is organised through the *kulīna* system, attributed in tradition to the Sena king Ballala Sena (r. c. 1158–1179 CE). Five Kayastha surnames achieved *kulīna* status through the legend of Kannauj migration: Bose/Basu, Ghosh, Mitra, Guha, and Datta. The historical veracity of this legend has been questioned: Bellenoit analyses the kulin origin narrative as a community-constructed social claim actively contested in colonial courts,¹⁹ and Pagani *et al.* found that individual Kayastha families designated as *kulin* show genuinely different genetic signatures — some consistent with the Kannauj story, others inconsistent with a common migration event.²⁰

Below the five Kulin clans, the Dakshina-Radhi tradition recognised **Maulika** (“origi-

nal/fundamental”) families. A verse from the *Kulpradipa*, quoted in Basu (1933),¹⁰ names the eight *Siddha Maulika* families:

“প্রথমে দেববংশ দত্ত কর পালিত। সেন সিংহ দাস ওত বিচার সঙ্গত।”

“Deva-dynasty, Datta, Kar, Palita, Sen, Singha, Das — these are the *Siddha Maulika* families.” The Deva-dynasty (*devabamsha*) is named first in this metrical enumeration — in the Dakshin-Radhi tradition, the Dey family is consistently listed as one of the eight *Siddha Maulika* families, an attested position (Category B) reflecting genuine status within the western Bengal hierarchy.

5.4 The Bangaja System and the Mahapatra Status of De/Dey

The Dakshina-Radhi system described above governed primarily western Bengal. Eastern Bengal — the *Vangaja* (“born of Vanga”) tradition — developed a parallel system organised under the patronage of the Deva dynasty. The Bangaja hierarchy, as preserved in Basu’s *Dakshin Rariya Kayastha-kanda* (1933) and Brihaspati’s *Bangaja Kayastha Karika*,¹⁰ recognised three *Maulika* sub-tiers: *Madhalya* (lower), *Siddha* (middle), and **Mahapatra** (highest). The full hierarchy places, in order: five Kulin families (Bose, Ghosh, Mitra, Guha, Datta), Bansaj hereditary lineages, and then the three *Maulika* tiers. *Mahapatra* — the highest *Maulika* sub-tier — comprised nineteen specific lineage branches, including the Deva/Dey family.

A critical qualification follows from Inden’s analysis: *Mahapatra* status was awarded to a specific branch of a specific family of a specific gotra — not to all Dey families across the board.³ The rank is lineage-specific, adjudicated by the *ghataka* at individual marriages.

The *Mahapatra* classification of De/Dey is confirmed by an independent source that predates Basu’s principal Bangaja volumes. Lalmohan Vidyanidhi’s *Sambandha Nirnaya* (1896) — a Kayastha social guide produced independently — provides at page 151:

“সেন, সিংহ, দে ও রাহা এই চারি ঘরকে মহাপাত্র সংজ্ঞার অভিহিত করে।”

“Sen, Singh, **De**, and Raha — these four houses are called *Mahapatra*.”¹¹

This 1896 source specifically confirms De/Dey as one of precisely four families designated *Mahapatra* in the Bangaja system, independent of Basu’s compilation.

The *Sambandha Nirnaya* presents the full 27-family Bangaja Kayastha hierarchy: at the apex, three Kulin surnames (Guha, Ghosh, Basu); below them *Madhyam* (Datta, Nag, Nath, Das); then four *Mahapatra* houses (Sen, Singh, **De/Dey**, Raha); followed by fifteen or more *Samanya Maulik* families (Kar, Dhar, Bhadra, Nandi, Dam, Pal, Chandra, Palit,

Nandan, Kunda, and others). De/Dey is one of four families at the highest tier within the entire Maulika division.

The founding figure. The Bangaja Kayastha social tradition identifies a specific founding Mahapatra representative of the Deva dynasty: **Shikhi-dhvaja** (শিখিধ্বজ). Basu's *Kayastha Barna Nirnay* (1913) names him: “দেববংশাঘুজ মহাবাহু শিখিধ্বজ” — “Shikhi-dhvaja, of great valour, born of the Deva dynasty” — listing him as the Deva dynasty representative among the founding Mahapatra figures.¹²

Territorial organisation. Girishchandra Basu's *Kayastha Puran* (1928) states: “লাঙ্গলবন্ধ, রামপাল, বিক্রমপুর ও চন্দ্রদ্বীপ অতি প্রাচীন কালাবধি পরিচিত স্থান। এখানেই বঙ্গজ সমাজ স্থাপিত হইয়াছে।” — “Langalbandh, Rampal, Bikrampur, and Chandradwip are known from ancient times. The Bangaja society was established here.”²¹ The five administrative branches (*shakha*) of Bangaja Kayastha society were: Chandradwip (Bakla), Jessore, Bikrampur, Fatehabad, and Baju.²¹ The Mymensingh branch of the Bangaja system falls within the Bikrampur or Fatehabad sub-society — central Bengal territory from which Mymensingh's Bangaja families drew their genealogical affiliation.

The De/Dey family thus occupies two parallel positions: in the Dakshin-Radhi (western Bengal) tradition — Siddha Maulika, named first in the Kulpradipa verse; in the Bangaja (eastern Bengal) tradition — Mahapatra, the highest Maulika sub-tier. For eastern Bengal Dey families, including those of Mymensingh, the Bangaja classification is the operative one. Basu's *Uttarrariya Kayastha-kanda* (1929) covers seven North Radhi families and does not include the Deva dynasty,²² positively confirming that the De/Dey family is a Bangaja (East Bengal) family, not a North Radhi one.

6. Colonial Documentation: Census, Ethnography, and the Courts

Risley's *Tribes and Castes of Bengal* (1891: 216) lists “De” as a surname associated primarily with Kayastha communities but also found among Suvarna Banik and several other castes — confirming the general pattern of cognomen diffusion.¹ Risley's broader classification of Bengali Kayasthas as Shudra was deeply contested by the Bengali Kayastha community: the 1884 judicial determination in *Rajcoomar Lal v. Bissessur Dayal* — that Bengali Kayasthas were Shudra — galvanised the community into forming the Kayastha Sabha.¹⁹

J.H. Hutton, Census Commissioner for 1931, wrote that Kayastha is “an important caste, which in Bengal ‘ranks next to Brahman’”; by 1931 the caste was “commonly regarded as twice-born” and “itself claims to be Kshatriya, though it was perhaps more

often regarded as clean Sudra a hundred years ago.”²³ This trajectory reflects the social mobility of the *bhadralok* class during the colonial period. Eaton’s formulation captures the structural tension: the Bengali Kayastha community became “the region’s surrogate Kshatriya or warrior class” — performing Kshatriya functions without receiving Kshatriya ritual recognition.¹⁵ The *Ain-i-Akbari* (c. 1590s) records Bengal’s administrative structures under Akbar; Bengali Kayasthas were among the most prominent beneficiaries of Todar Mal’s revenue settlement. The Sachse *Gazetteer of Mymensingh District* (1917) notes: “Most of the zamindars belong to Brahman or Kayastha families.”²⁴

7. Genetic Evidence: The De/Dey Family and Population Genetics

The foundational framework established by Reich *et al.* (2009) identified two ancestral South Asian populations: Ancestral North Indians (ANI) and Ancestral South Indians (ASI).²⁵ This was substantially refined by Narasimhan *et al.* (2019), which established that steppe-related ancestry entered South Asia in the early second millennium BCE, carried by pastoralists via the Bactria-Margiana Archaeological Complex.²⁶ Bengali populations carry a third component absent in most other South Asian mainland communities: East Asian-related ancestry at approximately 7–15%, reflecting ancient Austro-Asiatic admixture.²⁷ For East Bengali communities, including those from Mymensingh, the East Asian component is approximately 13–15%.

The only published direct genetic test of a Bengali Dey individual appears in Pagani, Bose, Ayub, and Tyler-Smith (2017), “Kayasthas of Bengal: Legends, Genealogies, and Genetics,” *Economic and Political Weekly* 52(47).²⁰ The study genotyped twelve Bengali Kayastha adults using the 23andMe platform at approximately 500,000 genetic variants; the Kayastha sample included four *kulin* surnames (Bose, Ghosh, Datta, Guha) and four *maulik* surnames (Dey, Pal, Nandi, Indra).

Y-chromosome result: The Dey sample carries Y-haplogroup **H1a***. H-M69 is estimated to be 30,000–50,000 years old and represents an ancient indigenous South Asian paternal lineage — the oldest stratum of South Asian Y-chromosome diversity, predating Indo-Aryan steppe migration. The Dey sample’s mtDNA is haplogroup **M2** — the dominant ancient maternal lineage across all South Asian communities.²⁸

Autosomal ancestry: Pagani *et al.* found that the closest reference populations to the Dey lineage were Sakilli (Kerala, distance 0.063), Nihali (Maharashtra, 0.070), and Malayan (Kerala, 0.094) — all South Indian or Central Indian populations. North Indian Kayastha (Srivastava) ranked ninth at distance 0.164. The paper states explicitly:

“While Bose and Pal lineages seem to indicate a predominant origin in Uttar Pradesh and western India, **the Dey lineage points to modern south Indians as their best genetic match.**”²⁰

Interpretation: The H1a* Y-haplogroup and South Indian autosomal affinity converge on a coherent interpretation: the paternal line of this Bengali Dey family is not steppe-derived, and the autosomal ancestry reflects higher AASI (Ancient Ancestral South Indian) composition than the kulin families. This is consistent with the kulagrantha classification of Deys as *maulika* — original Bengal stock, not Kannauj migrants.

Limitations: The Pagani *et al.* result derives from a **single individual**. A single Y-haplogroup result cannot be treated as representative of the Dey community, which the ten-gotra schema itself indicates comprises multiple distinct patrilineal branches. A dedicated genetic study of Bengali Dey families — sampling 20–50 males with geographic stratification — is urgently needed before the H1a* haplogroup can be treated as characteristic of the community as a whole.

8. The Deys of Mymensingh: A Micro-Historical Case Study

8.1 The Historical Context

Mymensingh district — the vast, riverine district of north-eastern Bengal straddling the lower Brahmaputra valley — provides the geographical setting for one recoverable chapter of De/Dey family history. The district’s population in 1911 was nearly three-quarters Muslim; the district town of Mymensingh (“Nasirabad”), however, was overwhelmingly Hindu — 78% of the town population in the last pre-Partition census. The Sachse *Gazetteer* (1917) confirms: “Most of the zamindars belong to Brahman or Kayastha families.”²⁴ Nirad C. Chaudhuri’s *Autobiography of an Unknown Indian* (1951) illustrates the social world of the district’s Hindu elite: interlocking kinship networks, strict marriage hierarchy, and intense consciousness of *kula* (clan) status.²⁹

Crucially, Basu’s own primary source network extended into this district. Basu’s *Kayastha Kanda* identifies Gobindachandra Deb Roy — High Court advocate, western Mymensingh — as the man who sent Basu the Batu Bhatta kulagrantha manuscript: “অধুনা পশ্চিম ময়মনসিংহবাসী হাইকোর্টের উকীল প্রযুক্ত গৌবিন্দচন্দ্র দেব রায় মহাশয় পুথিখানি পাঠাইয়াছেন। পুরুষানুক্রমে এই কুলগ্রন্থখানি তাহাদের গৃহে শ্রাদ্ধাদিকালে পঠিত হইয়া আসিতেছে।”⁹ — “From generation to generation, this kulagrantha has been recited at *shraddha* ceremonies in their home.” The manuscript was held by Kshitindra Deb Roy of Purya village, Mymensingh.

8.2 Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey (AIR 1938 Cal 216)

The primary surviving documentary record for the De/Dey family of Mymensingh in this period is a published judgment of the Calcutta High Court: *Loke Nath Sen v. Aswini Kumar Dey*, decided on 1 September 1937 by Justice Biswas.³⁰ The complainant — **Aswini Kumar De** (rendered “Dey” in the case title, reflecting East Bengali orthographic variation) — was an umbrella manufacturer operating from **Mymensingh Burra Bazar**. Aswini Kumar De is the author’s grandfather.

The brand: Aswini Kumar De’s umbrella business, established by approximately 1912 and of “over 25 years’ standing” by the 1937 judgment, traded under the name “**Aswini Chhata**” (Aswini’s Umbrella). His trademark, registered on **23 August 1926** as **Registry No. 964**, featured a **swan (*haṃsa*) holding a closed umbrella between its beaks**, the quality grade “8 A 4,” and an oval impression reading “Aswini Kumar De Marka.”

The legal action: Loke Nath Sen had manufactured umbrellas deliberately imitating the brand — substituting “Sree Aswini Kumar Das” for “Aswini Kumar De,” reproducing the swan-and-umbrella imagery, changing the grade mark from “8 A 4” to “84,” and substituting “965” for “964” in the registration impression. A trial magistrate convicted Sen under Indian Penal Code Sections 482 and 486, imposing fines of Rs. 100 under each section. On appeal to the Calcutta High Court, Justice Biswas reversed the conviction on a technical ground: in the absence of a Trade Marks Act for India (not passed until 1940), multiple Mymensingh umbrella manufacturers all used variants of the swan-and-umbrella imagery with “84” grade marks, making the design elements generic in the local trade. Biswas, however, explicitly accepted the brand name’s commercial standing: “By Aswini Chhata, people mean the umbrella with Aswini brand manufactured by Aswini Kumar Dey of Burrabazar, Mymensingh. I do not know of any other brand of Aswini Chhata in the market.”³⁰

8.3 Portrait of a Bhadrak Lok Manufacturer

The details embedded in the judgment yield a portrait of a specific *bhadrak lok* life in colonial Mymensingh whose surname, name construction, profession, legal sophistication, and market position are all consistent with Bangaja Kayastha identity. The Kayastha inference rests on four converging indicators: (i) the De/Dey surname is overwhelmingly Kayastha in the Bangaja tradition; (ii) the name *Aswini Kumar* follows the characteristic Sanskrit-honorific construction of educated Kayastha families — *Aswini* references the twin Ashwini Kumars of the Rigveda, the divine physicians; (iii) the Burra Bazar com-

mercial address is consistent with the *bhadralok* merchant-professional class; and (iv) legal representation before the Calcutta High Court by “Mr. Basu” — a Kulin Kayastha advocate — is consistent with the social networks of the Kayastha professional world. None of these indicators constitutes proof; together they make the inference probable.

The swan (*haṃsa*) trademark is far from a random commercial choice. The *haṃsa* is the vehicle (*vāhana*) of Brahma the creator, and in Upanishadic literature the *paramahansa* is the archetype of spiritual liberation. In the commercial culture of colonial Bengal, where Hindu manufacturers routinely used sacred imagery to signal trustworthiness, a swan-branded umbrella was a statement of Hindu, educated, legitimate identity. Aswini Kumar De’s trademark registration in 1926 further demonstrates legal awareness, understanding of the colonial registration system, and commercial foresight characteristic of the *bhadralok* professional class.

8.4 The Genealogical Network in Mymensingh

The co-presence in 1900s–1930s Mymensingh of the following four individuals, all operating within the same Bangaja Kayastha social world, is historically significant:

1. **Aswini Kumar De** — umbrella manufacturer, Mymensingh Burra Bazar; trademark 1926, court case 1937.
2. **Gobindachandra Deb Roy** — High Court advocate, western Mymensingh; transmitted the Deva dynasty kulagrantha (*Batu Bhatta’s Deva Bangsha*) to Basu c. 1910–1914.
3. **Kshitindra Deb Roy** — kulagrantha custodian, Purya village, Mymensingh; held the c. 1700 CE copy of the Batu Bhatta text.
4. **Bhairavachandra Ray** — advocate, Kishoreganj (Mymensingh district); at whose home the ancient *Devavansha* (“দেববংশ”) manuscript was found c. 1908 CE.

These four individuals — manufacturer, kulagrantha transmitter, manuscript custodian, and independent manuscript-holder — represent four distinct strands of *bhadralok* Kayastha life in the same district during its final pre-Partition generation. This contextual relationship is suggestive but not documentary: it establishes proximity within the same district and social class, not proven genealogical connection between these specific families.

The inferential chain. The connection between the author’s documented family and the Karnasuvarna Deva dynasty rests on four inferential steps: (i) the De/Dey surname in Bangaja East Bengal is overwhelmingly associated with the Bangaja Kayastha Deva dynasty’s social sphere — confirmed across five independent kulagrantha compilations

(confidence: **high**); (ii) Bangaja Kayastha De/Dey families are classified as belonging to the Deva dynasty's genealogical system — Mahapatra tier, one of 27 Bangaja families (confidence: **high**); (iii) the author's confirmed family gotra is Kashyapa — the fifth of the ten gotras in the Deva dynasty's tradition (confidence: **moderate** — Kashyapa is a pan-Indian gotra; it is consistent with, but does not exclusively prove, Deva dynasty membership); (iv) the dynasty's own genealogy traces it back to Karnasuvarna — **Category C** evidence, single manuscript chain, without epigraphic corroboration. The link between the author's documented twentieth-century family and the medieval Karnasuvarna Deva clan is **probable on the balance of circumstantial evidence, but unproven by direct documentation**. What would close the gap: a ghatak register entry naming the De family of Mymensingh Burra Bazar; a caste statement in a colonial administrative document; or a Y-DNA result placing the paternal line within a subclade shared with confirmed Deva/Dey family members.

8.5 The World That Was Lost

Aswini Kumar De's world was erased by the Partition of Bengal, implemented with the Radcliffe Line on 17 August 1947. The Hindu population of Mymensingh town was overwhelmingly displaced over the following years. The *bhadralok* commercial world of Mymensingh Burra Bazar ceased to exist as a Hindu commercial space. What the Partition could not erase is the documentary record. AIR 1938 Cal 216 survives. Trademark Registry No. 964, dated 23 August 1926, is a permanent entry in the colonial registration records. And the Batu Bhatta kulagrantha manuscript, sent from Mymensingh to Nagen-dranath Basu and preserved in Basu's *Rajanya Kanda* (1914), transmits a genealogical tradition in which that commercial family participated — even if the precise genealogical connection between the Deb Roy kulagrantha custodians and the De family of the Burra Bazar cannot be established on the current evidence.

9. Conclusion

This paper has traced the De/Dey family of eastern Bengal through five intersecting analytical frameworks — etymology, epigraphy, caste sociology, population genetics, and local family history — and arrived at conclusions differentiated by their evidentiary basis.

Established with confidence (*Category A or B* evidence): The surname De/Dey derives from Sanskrit *deva* through a regular phonological pathway. The crystallisation of

the surname as a hereditary Kayastha identifier is plausibly dated to the period 1231–1317 CE, in association with the documented Deva dynasty of Bikrampur and Sonargaon. The De/Dey family holds Mahapatra status in the Bangaja system and is consistently listed as one of the eight Siddha Maulika families in the Dakshin-Radhi tradition — rankings cross-attested across multiple independent kulagrantha compilations. De/Dey is primarily a Kayastha surname, not a Vaishya lineage surname, though the cognomen appears in secondary usage across several Bengali castes.

Established within the kulagrantha tradition, with partial independent corroboration (*Category B* evidence): The ten-gotra internal structure; the specific Shandilya identification of the *kulanayak* royal branch; the role of Danujamardana as the organiser and founder of the Bangaja social system (now attested independently in Girishchandra Basu, 1928, as well as Nagendranath Basu’s compilation). The **Alambana** gotra as the primary gotra of Bangaja Maulik Dey families — distinct from the Shandilya gotra of the royal branch — is now attested in three sources (Sambandha Nirnaya 1896, Kayastha Barna Nirnay 1913, Kayastha Tattwa-Koumodi 1928), elevating this specific claim toward Category B. The dynasty’s roots at Karnasuvarna remain Category C: resting on a single manuscript chain and not independently corroborated by epigraphic or numismatic evidence.

Contested in the historiographic literature: The identity of Danujamardana remains unresolved. The dominant numismatic tradition (Bhattachali, Majumdar, Banglapedia) identifies the Danujamardana coins with Raja Ganesha of Bhaturia; Eaton’s revisionist view distinguishes two figures but does not endorse the specifically Kayastha genealogical claim; only the kulagrantha tradition makes the full Chandradwip-Kayastha-Karnasuvarna argument. This paper follows the kulagrantha tradition for the social-historical argument while acknowledging the contested numismatic context.

The genetic evidence from Pagani *et al.* (2017) — a single Bengali Dey individual — shows Y-haplogroup H1a* and South Indian autosomal affinity consistent with indigenous Bengal stock rather than steppe-derived or North Indian origin. This is consistent with the *maulika* classification, but cannot be treated as representative of the Dey community as a whole without a substantially larger study.

The micro-historical case study of Aswini Kumar De of Mymensingh Burra Bazar documents a specific *bhadralok* life with archival certainty: a manufacturer who built a recognised umbrella brand over a quarter-century, registered his trademark with the colonial administration, fought counterfeiter through the courts of British India, and left — in the pages of the *All India Reporter* — a permanent mark in the historical record. The connection between that documented life and the Karnasuvarna Deva dynasty is

probable — resting on surname, gotra, geography, and social class as four consistent circumstantial indicators — but it is not established by direct documentation. Section 8.4 sets out precisely what that gap entails and what evidence would be required to close it.

The living kulagrantha network of the same district — represented by Gobindachandra Deb Roy and Kshitindra Deb Roy in western Mymensingh — shows that the medieval genealogical tradition was still operative in the world in which Aswini Kumar De traded. That contextual proximity is historically meaningful even where genealogical connection cannot be proven. The micro-historical and the macro-historical are not separate domains; they are the same history, documented at different scales and at different levels of evidentiary confidence.

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